

THE ILLITERATE WRITER'S

FILM FORUM

THE ELEMENTS OF FILM · PART ONE · STORY

CHAPTER 1 · STRUCTURE

Rules Before We Break Them

SUNSET BLVD. · THE ROAD WE DID NOT

Sullivan's Travels · 1941 · 90 min · written and directed by
Preston Sturges

CHAPTER 1 OF 9

This is the print edition, with everything the online guide has. Some information will include spoilers, advised to stop at the end of "Before you press play" and resume after the credits.

THE TWO ROADS

STRAIGHT ON, OR A LEFT AT THE VISTA

Hollywood Boulevard runs east until it hits Sunset, and there is a theatre standing on the corner where they meet. Every chapter the room decides at that corner, and this one went straight on.

SUNSET BLVD.

SULLIVAN'S TRAVELS

NOT SELECTED

1941 · 90 min · written and directed by Preston Sturges

The same machine, turned on itself. A director who has decided the movies he is good at are worthless goes looking for something worth filming, and the film keeps changing genre underneath him. Kept here in full, for extra credit.

BEFORE YOU PRESS PLAY

THIS MOVIE IS PICKING A FIGHT WITH OTHER MOVIES

Sturges, in his own memoir: *"After I saw a couple of pictures put out by some of my fellow comedy-directors, which seemed to have abandoned the fun in favor of the message, I wrote Sullivan's Travels to satisfy an urge to tell them that they were getting a little too deep-dish; to leave the preaching to the preachers."*

A studio executive in the film says the words **"What's the matter with Capra?"** out loud.

Worth being precise about: Sturges named Capra in the script, but never said publicly that Capra was who he meant. Everyone assumes it.

THE MAN WHO INVENTED THE JOB OF WRITER-DIRECTOR

In August 1939, Sturges handed Paramount a screenplay he had been sitting on for six years, *The Great McGinty*, **for ten dollars**, on the single condition that they let him direct it. They gave him \$350,000, a three week schedule and cheap talent. He won the first Academy Award for Best Original Screenplay ever given.

The credit read "Written and Directed by Preston Sturges," and by most accounts it was the first time those two verbs had appeared together on a talkie.

The ten dollars was partly studio publicity, since he was a contract writer on roughly \$2,500 a week. But the trade was real, and it is why the directing chair stopped belonging exclusively to directors.

IT COST \$689,665.16, AND THE LEADING LADY WAS SIX MONTHS PREGNANT

Shot May 12 to July 22, 1941, and came in **\$86,665.16 over budget**. **Veronica Lake was six months pregnant when principal photography began.** Edith Head designed the costumes to conceal it and a former Rose Bowl queen doubled her for the physical work. Her daughter was born a month after the wrap.

Accounts differ sharply on when Sturges found out. Lake's version: "It took physical restraint to keep him from boiling over at me." Other accounts say only Edith Head and

| *Sturges's wife knew.*

02

WHILE YOU WATCH

0:00

IT OPENS ON SOMEONE ELSE'S ENDING

Two men fighting on a speeding train, then "**The End.**" You are watching the last two minutes of a movie that does not exist. The camera pulls back into a screening room, and the argument that follows is reportedly **ten script pages in one unbroken take**, after the cinematographer dared Sturges to shoot it without a cut.

Why it matters: the thesis of the whole film is in the first five minutes, staged so you can't mistake it for a scene.

~45:00

THE TALKING STOPS

Sturges is the most word drunk filmmaker of his era. Then, for about **seven minutes**, everyone simply stops talking and music carries the picture.

Why it matters: he takes away his own best weapon. The silence is how the film tells you Sullivan has reached somewhere his script cannot cover. It took seven hours to shoot, four hours over schedule, the biggest overrun on the picture.

~1:12

WATCH THE FRAMING, NOT THE CARTOON

For eighty minutes Sullivan has been the subject of every shot. Here he becomes one face in a crowd.

Why it matters: the film makes its whole point with composition, several minutes before anybody says it out loud.

03

THE SHAPE OF IT



Same diagram, different problem. Casablanca's curve is tension. This one is tone, and the film falls off a cliff with it around the forty five minute mark. Four genres in ninety minutes, and Sturges does not smooth a single seam. The first two marks are named so you can see how to read it. The rest are yours to find.

04

OPEN AFTER THE CREDITS

The Coen brothers stole the title of the movie Sullivan wants to make

The grim Depression epic Sullivan is desperate to direct is called *O Brother, Where Art Thou?* It doesn't exist. In 2000 the Coens made a film with that title, which is, fittingly, a comedy.

Sturges wanted Chaplin for the church scene and was turned down

The cartoon the chain gang watches is Disney's "**Playful Pluto**" (1934), famous among animators for the flypaper gag, the first time an animated character really seemed to be thinking. Sturges asked to use Charlie Chaplin footage instead and was refused, which is interesting given that McCrea does a Little Tramp impression earlier in the film.

The head of the NAACP wrote to thank Sturges, and the actor went uncredited

NAACP secretary **Walter White** wrote to Sturges: *"I want to congratulate and thank you for the church sequence in Sullivan's Travels. This is one of the most moving scenes I have seen in a moving picture for a long time."*

And the preacher who delivers that welcome, **Jess Lee Brooks**, was left off the credits. The same film also contains a genuinely ugly racial gag in the land yacht chase. Both things are true at once, and that is worth an argument.

The U.S. government banned it from wartime export

The Office of Censorship formally disapproved the film for export during the war, specifically citing "the long sequence showing life in a prison chain gang" as unsuitable material to send abroad.

1941 critics could not agree what they had just watched

The New York Times: "the most brilliant picture yet this year," and put it on their ten best list. *The New Yorker*: "anyone can make a mistake, Preston Sturges, even. The mistake in question is a pretentious number called *Sullivan's Travels*." *The Hollywood Reporter*: "Laughter is the thing people want, not social studies."

Sturges himself noted that one reviewer wanted to know "what the hell the tragic passages were doing in this comedy," and another wanted to know "what the comic passages were doing in a drama." It entered the National Film Registry in 1990.

Sturges didn't know his own ending when he started writing

"When I started writing it I had no idea what Sullivan was going to discover... When I got down to there I found he still had one thing left: the ability to laugh."

The closing line, in full, because most people quote it wrong

"There's a lot to be said for making people laugh. Did you know that's all some people have? It isn't much, but it's better than nothing in this cockeyed caravan."

The version that gets passed around drops "Did you know that's all some people have?", which is the only part of the sentence with any teeth in it.

90:00

1 The third act reversal is triggered by *a pair of stolen shoes*, not by a decision. Sullivan spends the whole film *choosing* to be poor, and the second poverty becomes real, choice is exactly what gets taken away from him. Is that a cheat, or is that the entire point?

2 The film argues that making people laugh is enough. Does it *prove* that, or does it have to stop being funny for eighty minutes in order to earn the right to say it?

WHERE TO WATCH

Find it here → justwatch.com/us/movie/sullivans-travels, which shows every service carrying it right now, including free ones. It also lives permanently on [The Criterion Channel](#).

And two nobody uses: **Kanopy** and **Hoopla** are free with a library card, and between them they carry most of this. If you find it cheaper or free somewhere else, post the link in [my Substack](#).

WHY WE START HERE

ONE IS THE PERFECT ENGINE OF CLASSIC HOLLYWOOD STORYTELLING. THE OTHER WAS BUILT, ON PURPOSE, TO

TAKE THAT ENGINE APART WHILE IT'S STILL RUNNING.

In 1941, Preston Sturges made a movie about a director who has decided that the movies he is good at are worthless. One year later, Warner Bros. made a formula picture on a modest budget, on borrowed sets, with a script that wasn't finished when shooting started, and accidentally filmed the best argument anyone has ever made for exactly the kind of movie Sturges was defending. *Neither one knew about the other. They have been arguing ever since.*

Watch one. Or both. Then bring eighty four years of movies with you, and tell me what these two started.

THE STUDY

CLASSICAL HOLLYWOOD FOUNDATIONS

What “structure” means, and why we start in the 1940s.

WHY WE START WITH STRUCTURE

We're not just randomly watching films. We're following an overall story that will help us understand the medium better, and broaden what we even *think* is possible.

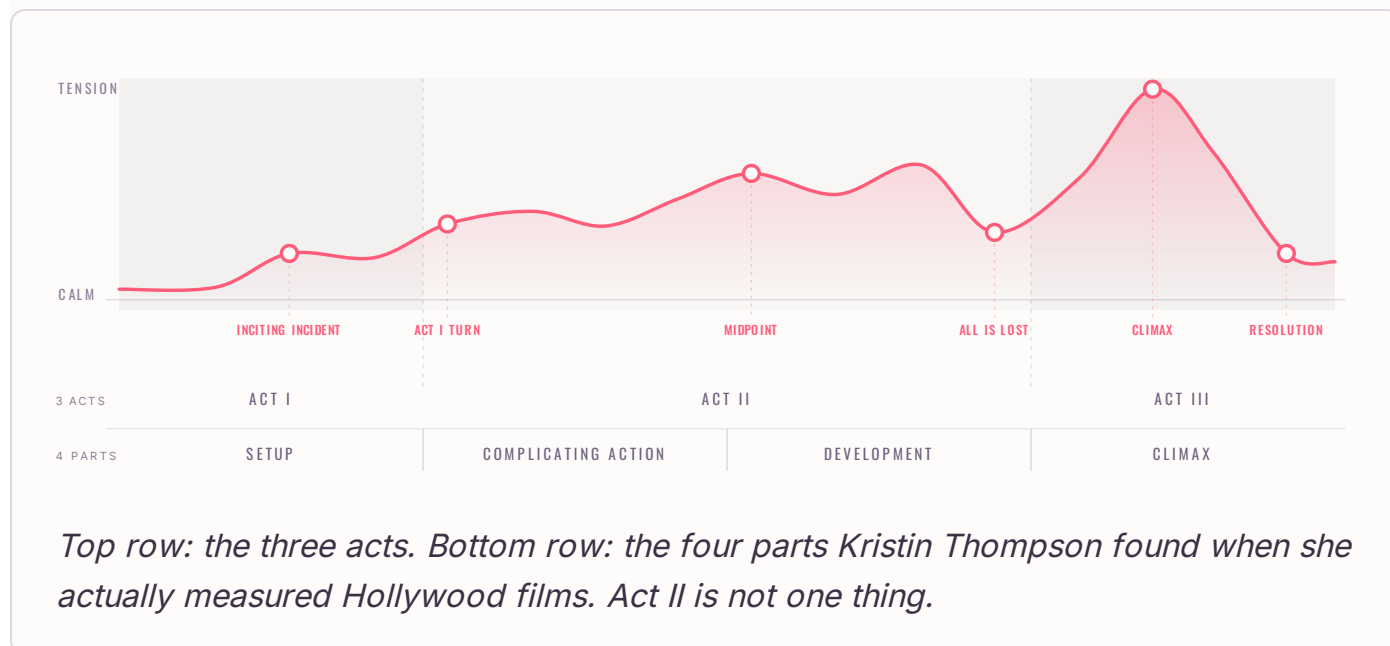
Chapter one is all about **structure**: how a story is presented, and how almost everything still follows, or deliberately rebels against, an ancient format that has been reintroduced and split apart for thousands of years.

If you've ever watched a movie and thought "how did they do that?", if you've ever loved a film so much you wanted the poster, the quote on a mug, the whole world of it, this is for you.

THE SHAPE EVERYONE DRAWS

A film is a contained experience, usually 90 to 120 minutes. That length matches how we hold attention in a dark room. Something happens, obstacles rise, stakes escalate, the story resolves. Cause leads to effect. **Structure is the invisible skeleton we rarely notice when it's working perfectly.**

Here is the diagram you have seen a hundred times.



It is worth knowing where that shape came from, because almost none of it came from film.

FREYTAG WAS WRITING ABOUT TRAGEDY, AND HE COUNTED FIVE

Gustav Freytag published *Die Technik des Dramas* in **1863**. He was analysing Sophocles, Shakespeare, and the German five act play. His model did not have three parts, rather, five.

- 1 *Einleitung*, the introduction
- 2 *Steigerung*, the rise
- 3 *Höhepunkt*, the climax
- 4 *Fall oder Umkehr*, the fall or the turn
- 5 *Katastrophe*

He was theorizing a structure that leads to **catastrophe**, rather than the school taught resolution stories we see all the time now. That last beat is the one that got quietly swapped out somewhere along the way.

Freytag died in 1895, the same year cinema went public. That December the Lumière brothers ran ten short films in the basement of a Paris café and sold tickets, the screening history decided to remember, even though Skladanowsky in Berlin and Latham in New York had both got there first.

Aristotle is the other main voice people reach for, usually by way of the *Poetics*. His beginning, middle, and end was a definition of wholeness, and was never meant as a blueprint. When he actually divides a tragedy, in chapter 18, he uses two halves, *desis* and *lusis*, the binding and the unbinding. The Greek plays he was writing about had no act structure at all.

THE RULEBOOK CAME 37 YEARS AFTER CASABLANCA

Funny enough, the three act rulebook was published in **1979**, in Syd Field's *Screenplay*. He attached page numbers to it.

- 1 **Act I**, pages 1 to 30
- 2 **Act II**, pages 31 to 90
- 3 **Act III**, pages 91 to 120
- 4 Plot points landing around page 25 and page 85

Casablanca and *Citizen Kane*, the two films everyone reaches for when they want to demonstrate the format, were made in 1942 and 1941. Neither was ever taught it the way we have been, because it did not exist yet.

Field was describing what films already did, and development executives then adopted it as a filter. David Bordwell, on the mechanism:

Once the three-act template became public knowledge, development executives embraced it as a way to make script acquisition routine.

A description hardened into a rule because it made saying no easier. And when Bordwell went into the archives looking for studio era writers who actually worked in acts, he came back with this:

I couldn't find any script draft broken into acts.

He found one exception. F. Scott Fitzgerald, writing *Infidelity* for MGM in 1938, laid out eight numbered sequences and grouped them into a first act of 45 pages, a second of 50, and a third of 25, nothing like the 30/60/30 that would come later. His working unit was the *sequence*, not the act.

SO WHAT WERE THEY ACTUALLY DOING

Kristin Thompson counted. In *Storytelling in the New Hollywood*, from 1999, she argues mainstream films break into **four large parts** rather than three acts, setup, complicating action, development, and climax, with a short epilogue after. Each one runs roughly 25 to 35 minutes.

Long films are the tell, **they do not get longer acts, they get more parts**. A three hour film tends to have six.

That is the bottom row on the diagram. The famously protracted second act is not one long act at all, it is two parts with a major turn sitting between them, which is why the midpoint of a film feels like a hinge rather than a middle.

WHAT ACTUALLY SHAPED A 1940S PICTURE

Runtime was set by exhibition. In 1938 the average Warner Bros. feature ran 75 minutes, MGM's ran 88. Double bills meant two features plus a newsreel, a cartoon, and a short all had to fit a turnover schedule, so the ceiling on length was set by the theatre's clock.

The Production Code taxed the third act specifically. It permitted a great deal in acts one and two, provided the ending restored the moral ledger. That is why so many pictures from this period have final reels that feel bolted on.

And the thing that did not shape it, the reel. A 1,000 foot reel runs about eleven minutes, and you will hear that reel changes created act breaks. There is no evidence for it anywhere in the scholarship. Changeover projection exists precisely to make the reel change invisible to the audience, and eleven does not divide into thirty.

WHY WE'RE STARTING HERE

This era crystallized the rules under real pressure. Budgets were tight. Locations were limited. Stories had to be efficient and emotionally clear. The war made personal drama feel urgent and universal. Filmmakers couldn't rely on spectacle, so they relied on script, character, and invisible craft.

So we are not here to learn the rules. We are here to learn the shape that a lot of people later mistook for rules, because that is the only way to tell, when you sit down in front of anything, whether a film is following it or fighting it.

BOTH ROADS END HERE

Two films set out to do the exact opposite thing, and both of them got there. One proved the rules work by obeying them without wasting a single move. The other proved the rules are negotiable by walking away from them halfway through and arriving anyway.

NEXT TIME YOU'RE IN A THEATRE, ASK WHICH ONE THE FILM IS DOING.
FOLLOWING THE SHAPE, OR FIGHTING IT.

WHERE THIS IS GOING

THE ELEMENTS OF FILM

Read it like a schoolbook. **Nine chapters in three parts**, one every two weeks, and every one of them stays up. Part One is the story itself: its shape, its clock, and who is telling it. This chapter is the rulebook, and everything after it is people breaking the rules on purpose.

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R. Julian Tuttle

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Film Forum · Part One · Chapter 1 · Field Guide

Questions, arguments, films you want on the ballot: heyilliteratewriter@gmail.com

Facts in this guide are drawn from the AFI Catalog, the Criterion Collection, the Library of Congress, TCM, Snopes, NPR and contemporary trade reporting.
Where sources disagree, the disagreement is printed rather than resolved.

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